use — Load Stata dataset

Description Quick start Menu Syntax Options Remarks and examples
Also see

Description

`use` loads into memory a Stata-format dataset previously saved by `save`. If *filename* is specified without an extension, `.dta` is assumed. If your *filename* contains embedded spaces, remember to enclose it in double quotes.

In the second syntax for `use`, a subset of the data may be read.

Quick start

Load Stata-format dataset `mydata.dta` into memory from current directory

```
use mydata
```

Same as above, but load data from the `mysubdir` subdirectory in current directory and clear current data from memory first

```
use mysubdir/mydata, clear
```

Load only variables `v1`, `v2`, and `v3` from `mydata.dta`

```
use v1 v2 v3 using mydata
```

Same as above, and further restrict to the first 100 observations

```
use v1 v2 v3 in 1/100 using mydata
```

Load observations from `mydata.dta` where `catvar` $= 2$

```
use if catvar==2 using mydata
```

Menu

File > Open...

Syntax

Load Stata-format dataset

```
use filename [ , clear nolabel ]
```

Load subset of Stata-format dataset

```
use [varlist] [if] [in] using filename [ , clear nolabel ]
```

Options

`clear` specifies that it is okay to replace the data in memory, even though the current data have not been saved to disk.

`nolabel` prevents value labels in the saved data from being loaded. It is unlikely that you will ever want to specify this option.

Remarks and examples

Example 1

We have no data in memory. In a previous session, we issued the command `save hiway` to save the Minnesota Highway Data that we had been analyzing. We retrieve it now:

```
. use hiway
(Minnesota Highway Data, 1973)
```

Stata loads the data into memory and shows us that the dataset is labeled "Minnesota Highway Data, 1973".

Example 2

We continue to work with our `hiway` data and find an error in our data that needs correcting:

```
. replace spdlimit=70 in 1
(1 real change made)
```

We remember that we need to forward some information from another dataset to a colleague. We `use` that other dataset:

```
. use accident
no; dataset in memory has changed since last saved
r(4);
```

Stata refuses to load the data because we have not saved the `hiway` data since we changed it.

```
. save hiway, replace
file hiway.dta saved
. use accident
(Minnesota accident data)
```

After we save our hiway data, Stata lets us load our accident dataset. If we had not cared whether our changed hiway dataset were saved, we could have typed use accident, clear to tell Stata to load the accident data without saving the changed dataset in memory.

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❑ Technical note

In example 2, you saved a revised hiway.dta dataset, which you forward to your colleague. Your colleague issues the command

```
. use hiway
```

and gets the message

```
file hiway.dta not Stata format
r(610);
```

Your colleague is using a version of Stata older than Stata 14. If your colleague is using Stata 11, 12, or 13, you can save the dataset in Stata 11, 12, or 13 format by using the saveold command; see [D] **save**.

Newer versions of Stata can always read datasets created by older versions of Stata. Stata/MP and Stata/SE can read datasets created by Stata/BE. Stata/BE can read datasets created by Stata/MP and Stata/SE if those datasets conform to Stata/BE's limits; see [R] **Limits**.

❑

▷ Example 3

If you are using a dataset that is too large for the amount of memory on your computer, you could load only some of the variables:

```
. use ln_wage grade age tenure race using
> https://www.stata-press.com/data/r19/nlswork
(National Longitudinal Survey of Young Women, 14-24 years old in 1968)
. describe
Contains data from https://www.stata-press.com/data/r19/nlswork.dta
 Observations:        28,534                  National Longitudinal Survey of
                                                Young Women, 14-24 years old in
                                                1968
    Variables:             5                  27 Nov 2024 08:14
                                              (_dta has notes)
------------------------------------------------------------------------------
Variable      Storage   Display    Value
    name         type    format    label      Variable label
------------------------------------------------------------------------------
age             byte    %8.0g                 Age in current year
race            byte    %8.0g      racelbl    Race
grade           byte    %8.0g                 Current grade completed
tenure          float   %9.0g                 Job tenure, in years
ln_wage         float   %9.0g                 ln(wage/GNP deflator)
------------------------------------------------------------------------------
Sorted by:
```

Stata successfully loaded the five variables.

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Example 4

You are new to Stata and want to try working with a Stata dataset that was used in example 1 of [XT] **xtlogit**. You load the dataset:

```
. use https://www.stata-press.com/data/r19/union
(NLS Women 14-24 in 1968)
```

The dataset is successfully loaded, but it would have been shorter to type

```
. webuse union
(NLS Women 14-24 in 1968)
```

`webuse` is a synonym for `use https://www.stata-press.com/data/r19/`; see [D] **webuse**.

Also see

[D] **compress** — Compress data in memory

[D] **datasignature** — Determine whether data have changed

[D] **frames use** — Load a set of frames from disk

[D] **import** — Overview of importing data into Stata

[D] **save** — Save Stata dataset

[D] **sysuse** — Use shipped dataset

[D] **webuse** — Use dataset from Stata website

[U] 11.6 Filenaming conventions

[U] 22 Entering and importing data

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